



The murder of Thomas Becket is depicted in stained glass at Canterbury Cathedral. Canonized in 1173, Becket became one of the most popular English saints.

“WILL NO ONE
RID ME OF THIS
TURBULENT
PRIEST?”

Attributed to **Henry II**, 1170

IN 1170, THOMAS BECKET, ARCHBISHOP OF CANTERBURY, was murdered in Canterbury Cathedral, England, by four knights of the court of **Henry II** (r. 1154–89). Although he swore that he had not ordered the crime, and was absolved of responsibility by **Pope Alexander** in 1172, Henry's famous outburst (see above) had prompted the action of the knights. The context for this outrage was an ongoing dispute over the extent of ecclesiastical

versus royal jurisdiction. During the anarchy of **Stephen's reign** (see 1136–40), clerical courts had encroached on areas previously under royal jurisdiction. Following Stephen's death, **Henry Plantagenet** came to the throne. He controlled England alongside the territories of Anjou, Normandy, and Aquitaine—known as the **Angevin Empire**—and set about instituting a badly needed reorganization of his new kingdom. **Taxation reforms**,

for instance, replaced the Danegeld with new levies, but it was the **judicial reform** that brought him into conflict with his friend and chancellor **Thomas Becket**. Becket had already been forced into exile after being found guilty of violating the **Constitutions of Clarendon** (see 1164). On his return he vexed Henry by **excommunicating** royally favored bishops.

At its height, in the late 12th century, the commercial **empire of Srivijaya**, based in Sumatra, controlled much of the **Malay Archipelago**. Its authority extended to colonies around the East Indies and as far as **Sri Lanka** and **Taiwan**. Srivijayan power was based almost exclusively on its **maritime prowess**. By securing the seas in the region against piracy, they enabled and directed **trade** between China, India, and the Islamic world, but imposition of heavy duties and taxes stoked resentment and, eventually, revolt.

Frederick I's fourth expedition to Italy, beginning in 1166, prompted the renewal of the **Lombard League** (see 1156–60) and the construction of the mighty fortress town **Alessandria**, named for the pope. With this citadel guarding the mountain passes, **Italy became virtually independent** of imperial authority.

Votive tablet

This votive tablet from the trading empire of Srivijaya is engraved with Buddhist figures. The ruling Sailendras were ardent Buddhists.



tablet in clay
with molded
design



Muhammad of Ghur, traveling by elephant, leads his army in the Islamic conquest of India.

THE GHURIDS WERE A DYNASTY **FOUNDED IN 1151** by Ala-ud-Din Husayn, who conquered much of **Ghaznavid Afghanistan** and founded a new state based at **Ghur** in western Afghanistan. In 1173, **Ghiyas-ud-Din** became emir, making his brother Mu'izz-du-Din, better known as **Muhammad of Ghur**, co-emir. Together the brothers brought most of Afghanistan under their control, and in 1175 Muhammad launched the **Islamic invasion** of northern India.

The Spanish rabbi **Benjamin of Tudela** (1130–73) was the **first recorded European** to have approached the borders of **China**, in an epic journey he made from 1159 to 1173. His account, *The Travels of Benjamin of Tudela*, recounts many exotic legends, including **Noah's Ark** resting on Mount Ararat.

In the medieval period, the city of **Pisa**, in Tuscany, became the center of a thriving **city-state**. Its cathedral was constructed in the 11th century, but in 1173 work began on a separate **bell tower**. Even during construction the foundations sank and the tower **began to slant**. Eventually it came to lean 15 ft (4.5 m) from the perpendicular.

During the 1170s, a new **religious movement** emerged in Lyons. Also known as the Poor Men of Lyons and the Vaudois, the **Waldenses** were led by Peter Walde (c. 1140–1218), a rich merchant who gave away his property and began to preach a radical creed of **gospel simplicity**



Leaning Tower of Pisa

Pisa's famous leaning tower is 179 ft (54.5 m) tall and 57 ft (17.5 m) in diameter at the base.

that rejected many of the teachings of Catholicism. Despite initial blessing by **Pope Alexander III**, the Waldensians' refusal to abide by his injunction against preaching led to their **denunciation as heretics** in 1179 and a long history of persecution (see 1206–10).

In 1174, the Zengid emir **Nur al-Din** died. His nephew **Saladin**, who had already assumed control of **Egypt**, quickly marched north to secure **Syria**, and was duly recognized as **sultan** of Egypt and Syria by the caliph in Baghdad, founding the **Ayyubid dynasty**.

